

1 Corinthians Part 1

The Cross and a Divided Church

BIG IDEA The crucified Christ overturns worldly measures of wisdom, power, and status. Church leaders are servants, the church belongs to God, and every believer belongs to Christ.

SERIES QUESTION What problem is Paul addressing, and how does the gospel answer it?

Corinth at a glance

Corinth was a prosperous Roman colony whose ports connected major trade routes. Its diverse and socially competitive culture valued wealth, ancestry, patrons, education, and impressive public speaking. Paul probably wrote from Ephesus around AD 54-55 after receiving reports of serious problems in the church.

The problem and the gospel answer

PASSAGE	MOVEMENT
1:1-17	God called the church by grace, but believers were using Christian leaders as competing badges of identity.
1:18-2:5	Christ crucified overturns worldly ideas of wisdom, power, status, and successful ministry.
2:6-3:4	The Spirit reveals God's wisdom, while jealousy and quarreling expose continued immaturity.
3:5-23	Leaders are servants and builders. God gives the growth, Christ is the foundation, and the church is God's temple.
4:1-21	Leaders are stewards accountable to God. Faithful ministry follows the self-giving pattern of the cross.

Paul Apollos Cephas and Christ

Paul reports four slogans: 'I follow Paul,' 'I follow Apollos,' 'I follow Cephas,' and 'I follow Christ.' Cephas is Peter. Scripture does not say Peter visited Corinth, though a later tradition connects him with the city. The slogans may describe exact factions, representative examples of party spirit, or both. Paul's conclusion is certain even when the faction map is not: Christ is not divided, and no church leader was crucified for them.

DISCUSS Do these slogans describe four exact factions, representative slogans, or some combination? What difference does your answer make - and what remains clear either way?

A different scorecard

WORLDLY SCORECARD	CROSS-SHAPED SCORECARD
Impressive personalities create loyalty	Servants point beyond themselves to Christ
Eloquence proves authority	The gospel's power rests in God
Status creates grounds for boasting	Grace leaves no room for boasting
The strongest leader produces growth	One plants, another waters, and God gives growth
Popularity gives the final verdict	The Lord evaluates each steward's faithfulness

Pictures of the church and its leaders

IMAGE	WHAT IT TEACHES
Servants	Paul and Apollos carry out assignments given by the Lord; neither owns the believers.
God's field	Leaders plant and water, but only God gives spiritual growth.
God's building	Christ is the foundation, and every builder will answer for the quality of the work.
God's temple	The congregation belongs to God and must not be damaged by jealousy, pride, or division.
Stewards	Christian leaders manage what belongs to Christ; the essential requirement is faithfulness.

The Gospel Then and Now

CHURCH REALITY THEN The Corinthians ranked leaders and one another by eloquence, wisdom, status, baptism, and visible success. Their boasting produced jealousy and division.

CHURCH TEMPTATION NOW Favorite pastors, theological tribes, political identities, worship preferences, education, wealth, programs, and church size can become substitutes for identity in Christ.

GOSPEL-SHAPED CHURCH The cross removes boasting. Leaders serve, God receives credit for growth, maturity appears in humble love, and the whole church remembers that it belongs to Christ.

Discuss

1. How do we decide whether a church or Christian leader is successful? Which parts of our scorecard would Paul challenge?
2. What evidence of spiritual immaturity does Paul identify? How can we use his words as a mirror rather than a weapon?
3. When does healthy appreciation for a pastor or teacher become unhealthy factional loyalty?
4. How can theological, political, or worship preferences become stronger identities than belonging to Christ?
5. What qualities should we seek in leaders who serve God's church?

For further study

ECO CONNECTION Essential Tenets II.B, the incarnation and saving work of Jesus Christ; III.A, God's grace in Christ; and III.C, covenant life in the church. eco-pres.org/constitution/

READ MORE ONLINE BibleProject, Book of 1 Corinthians Guide: bibleproject.com/guides/book-of-1-corinthians/

CLASS RESOURCES AND UPCOMING LESSONS

keithbreuer615.github.io/pauls-letters-class/



BEFORE NEXT WEEK Read 1 Corinthians 5-7. Mark the problems Paul addresses concerning church discipline, lawsuits, sexuality, marriage, divorce, and singleness. Notice how often Paul returns to the truth that believers belong to Christ.